

THE DECLINING BIRTH RATE IN THE UNITED STATES: SYSTEMIC FORCES OR PERSONAL CHOICE?

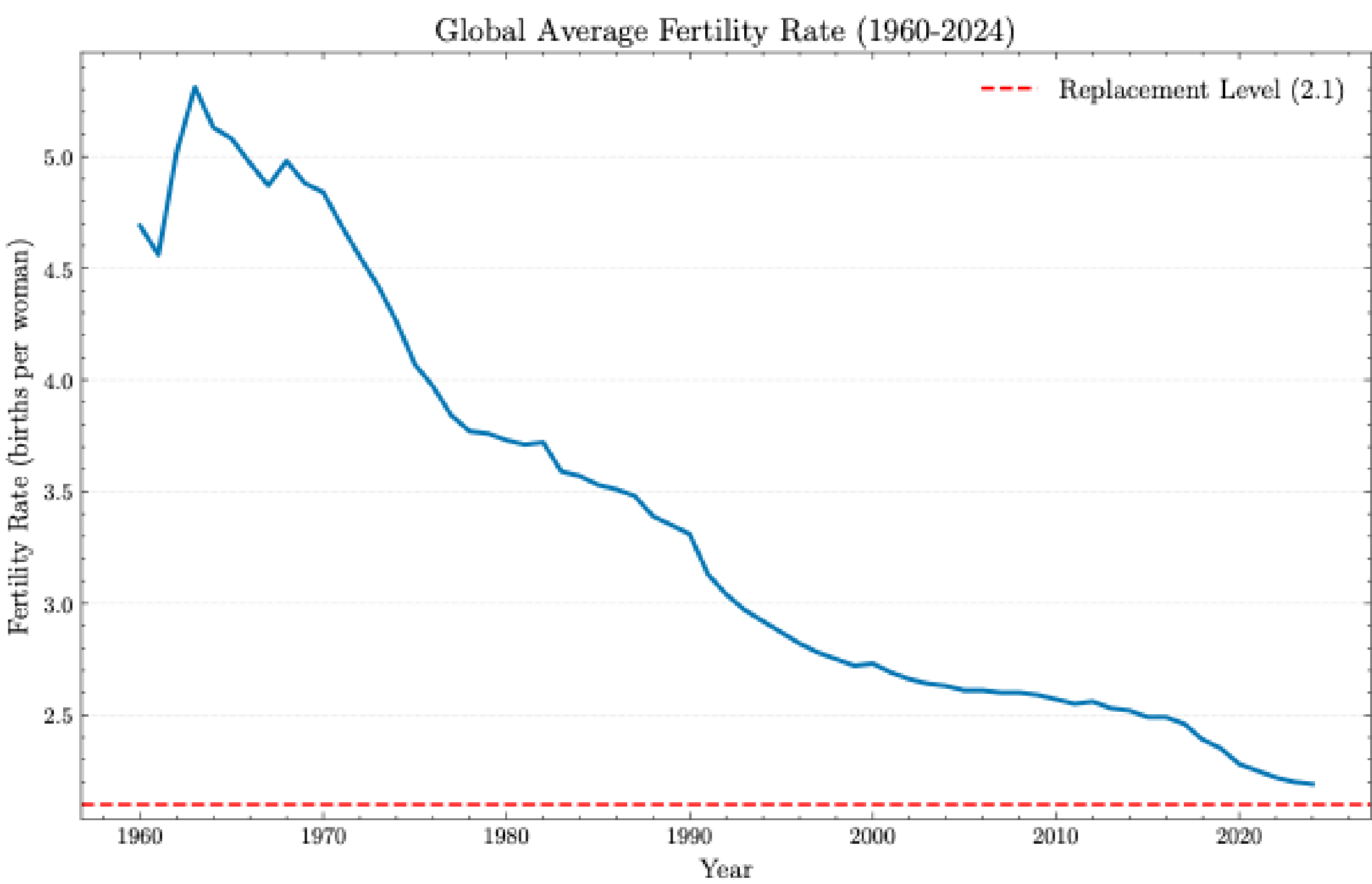
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ABSTRACT

U.S. birth rates have declined steadily over the past two decades, driven by a convergence of structural and personal factors. This case study organizes its analysis around four socioeconomic forces: economic precarity, time scarcity, family formation friction, and psychological climate, drawing on national and state-level datasets spanning several decades. To complement the structural analysis, discourse from four Reddit communities (r/Natalism, r/Childfree, r/Parenting, and r/Economics) was examined using TF-IDF analysis, LDA topic modeling, and framing analysis (2015-2025). Findings reveal that economic precarity is the dominant force shaping both the structural reality of declining birth rates and how Americans discuss the issue online, though its interpretation varies dramatically across ideological lines, from a systemic crisis demanding policy intervention to a rational personal choice.

CONTEXT

Global fertility rates have fallen from 5.0 births per woman in the 1960s to approximately 2.3 in 2024, approaching the replacement threshold of 2.1 which is very alarming. The United States mirrors this trend, recording birth rate declines across all 50 states. As a result, the pronatalist movement is gaining traction like never before, reigniting debates about the causes and consequences of declining fertility.



OBJECTIVES

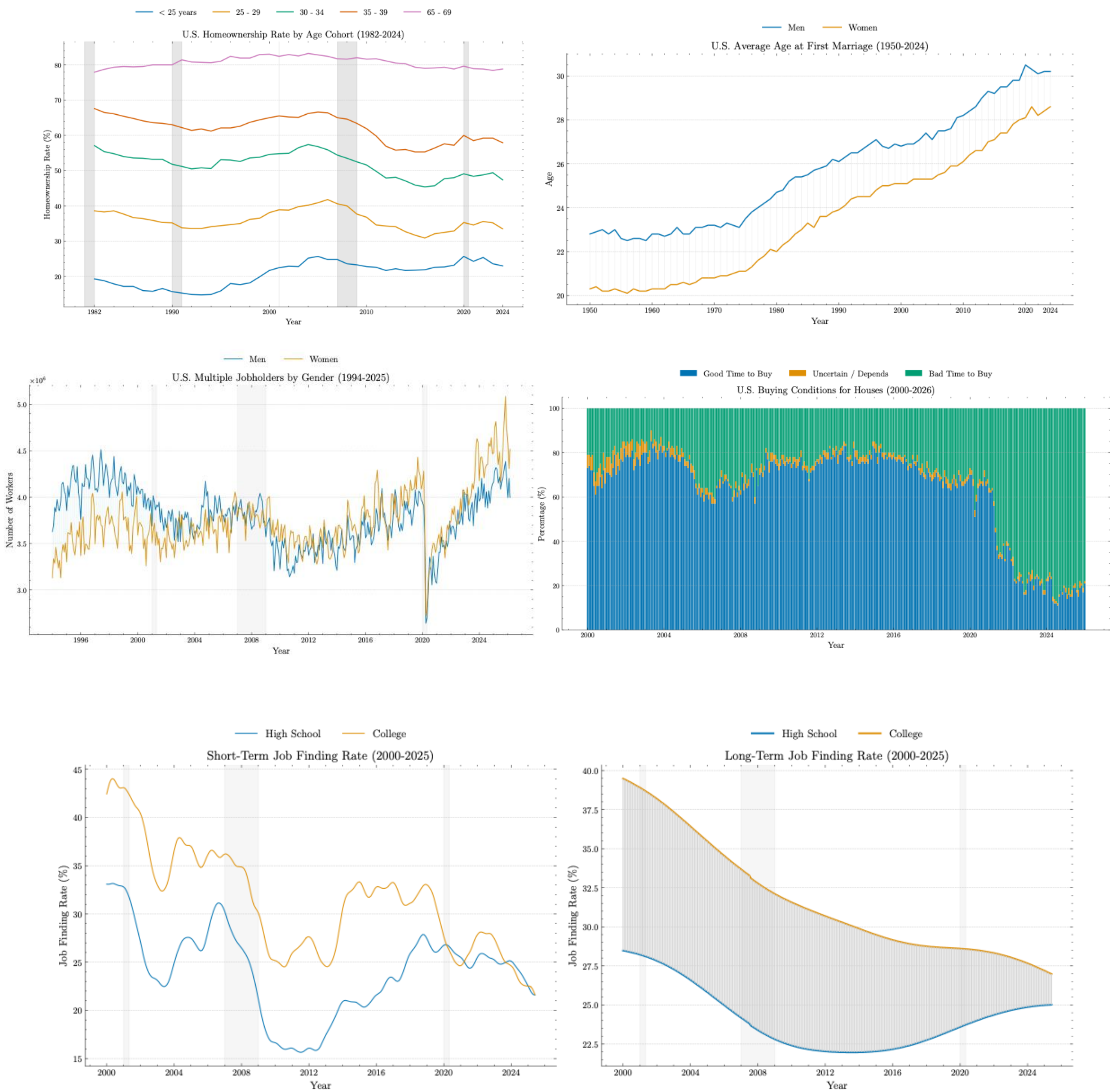
- Identify structural socioeconomic forces driving U.S. birth rate decline.
- Analyze birth rate discourse across ideologically distinct online communities.
- Assess alignment between structural evidence and public discourse.
- Evaluate competing explanations: systemic forces vs. personal choice.

METHODOLOGY

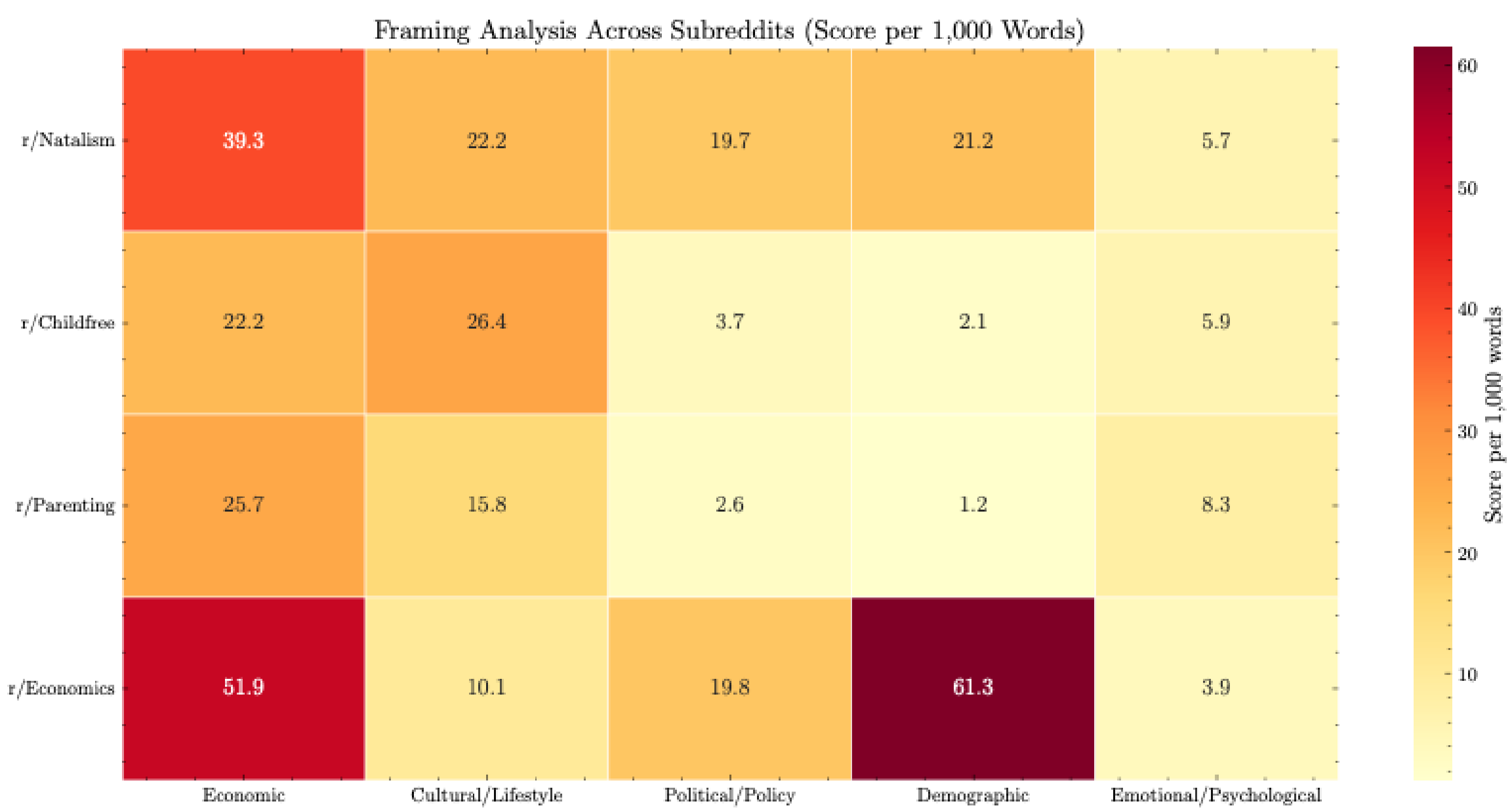
- Structural Analysis:
 - Economic Precarity: Poverty Rate, Housing Pressure, Homeownership, Household Debt Burden, Labor Market Stress, Childcare Costs.
 - Time Scarcity: Labor Force Participation, Multiple Jobholders Rate, Access to Paid Family Leave.
 - Family Formation Friction: Marriage Rates, Age at First Marriage, Divorce Rates, Age at First Birth.
 - Psychological Climate: Consumer Sentiment Index by Region, Age Cohort, Income Terciles, and Housing Buying Conditions.
- Discourse Analysis:
 - Four Reddit communities: r/Natalism, r/Childfree, r/Parenting, and r/Economics.
 - Timeframe: 2015-2025.
 - Sampling: Keyword-based sampling
 - Techniques: TF-IDF analysis, LDA topic modeling, framing analysis.

RESULTS

CHAPTER 2



CHAPTER 3



CONCLUSION

- Economic precarity is the dominant structural force driving U.S. birth rate decline, disproportionately affecting younger generations through housing costs, debt and childcare expenses.
- The job finding rate gap between college and high school graduates is narrowing, compounding family formation friction across socioeconomic groups.
- Time scarcity, delayed marriage and psychological pessimism reinforce economic barriers, creating a multi-dimensional obstacle to family formation.
- Economic concerns are universally acknowledged across the reddit communities yet interpreted differently from a systemic crisis demanding policy intervention to a rational personal choice.
- Addressing fertility decline requires a multidimensional approach that recognizes both its structural roots and the ideological complexity surrounding it.

REFERENCES

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Data sources: CDC, U.S. Census Bureau, Bureau of Labor Statistics, Federal Reserve, University of Michigan Survey of Consumers.

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